THE GROWTHX STUDIO

BUILD • GROW • SCALE

Steal Your Competitor's Audience on Meta Ads

The exact Custom Audience → Lookalike → Interest setup from our reel, step by step, with real Ads Manager screenshots.

⏱ 10-minute setup · No tools needed

THE PLAN

What you'll build

Three things, all inside Meta Ads Manager. Together they put your ads in front of people who behave like your best followers and like brands similar to your competitors.

① Engagement audience

Everyone who engaged with your Instagram profile. These are your warmest people.

② 1% Lookalike

New people Meta finds who look most like that engaged audience.

③ Competitor interest

Your competitor's brand name, added in detailed targeting if Meta lists it as an interest.

④ The ad set

Combine them in one ad set with your location (e.g. India) and best creative.

Before you start

- An **Instagram professional account** (Business or Creator) connected to your Meta Business portfolio.
- Admin or advertiser access to the **ad account** in Ads Manager.
- Some engagement history. A lookalike needs a source of **at least 100 people**; 1,000+ works much better.

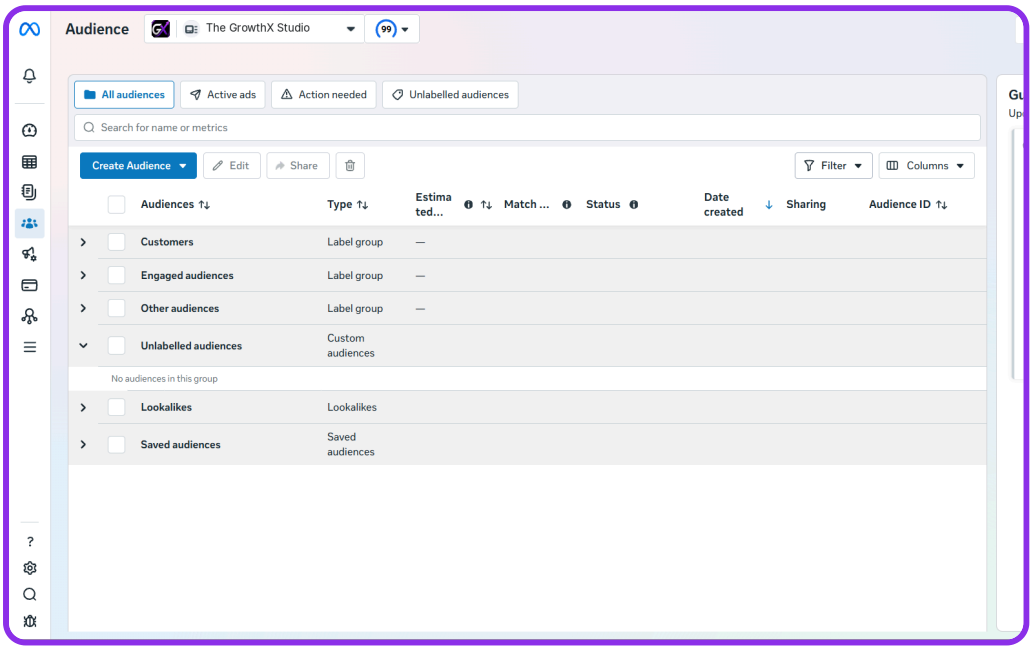
> **Why this works:** Meta's algorithm learns from the people you feed it. Starting from people who already engaged with you, then layering competitor-brand interests, gives it a high-intent seed instead of a cold, broad guess.

STEP 1

Open Audiences and create a Custom Audience

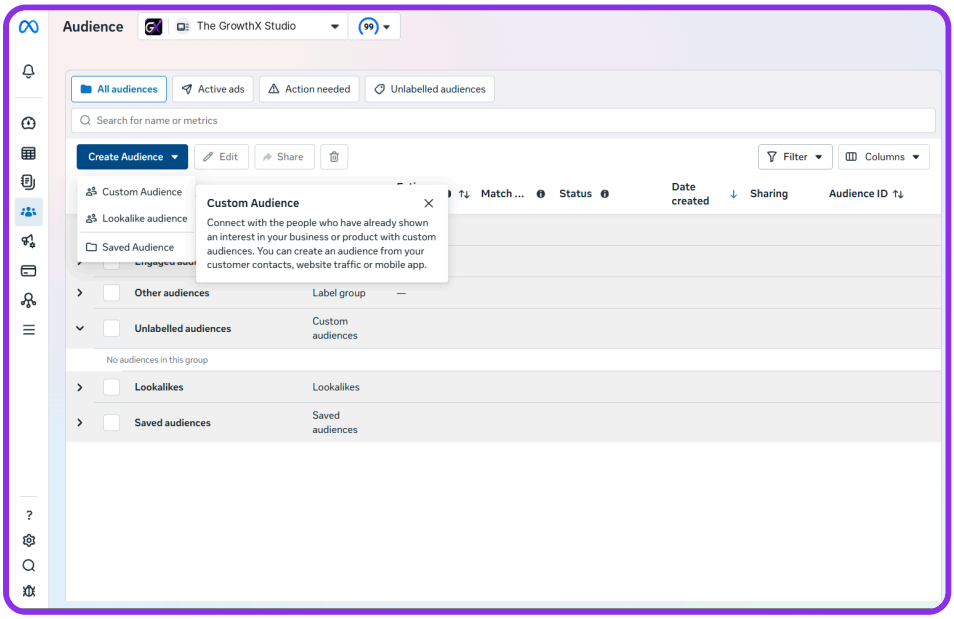
1. In Ads Manager, open the menu and go to **Audiences**.

2. Click the blue **Create Audience** button.



The Audiences page. The Create Audience button is at the top left.

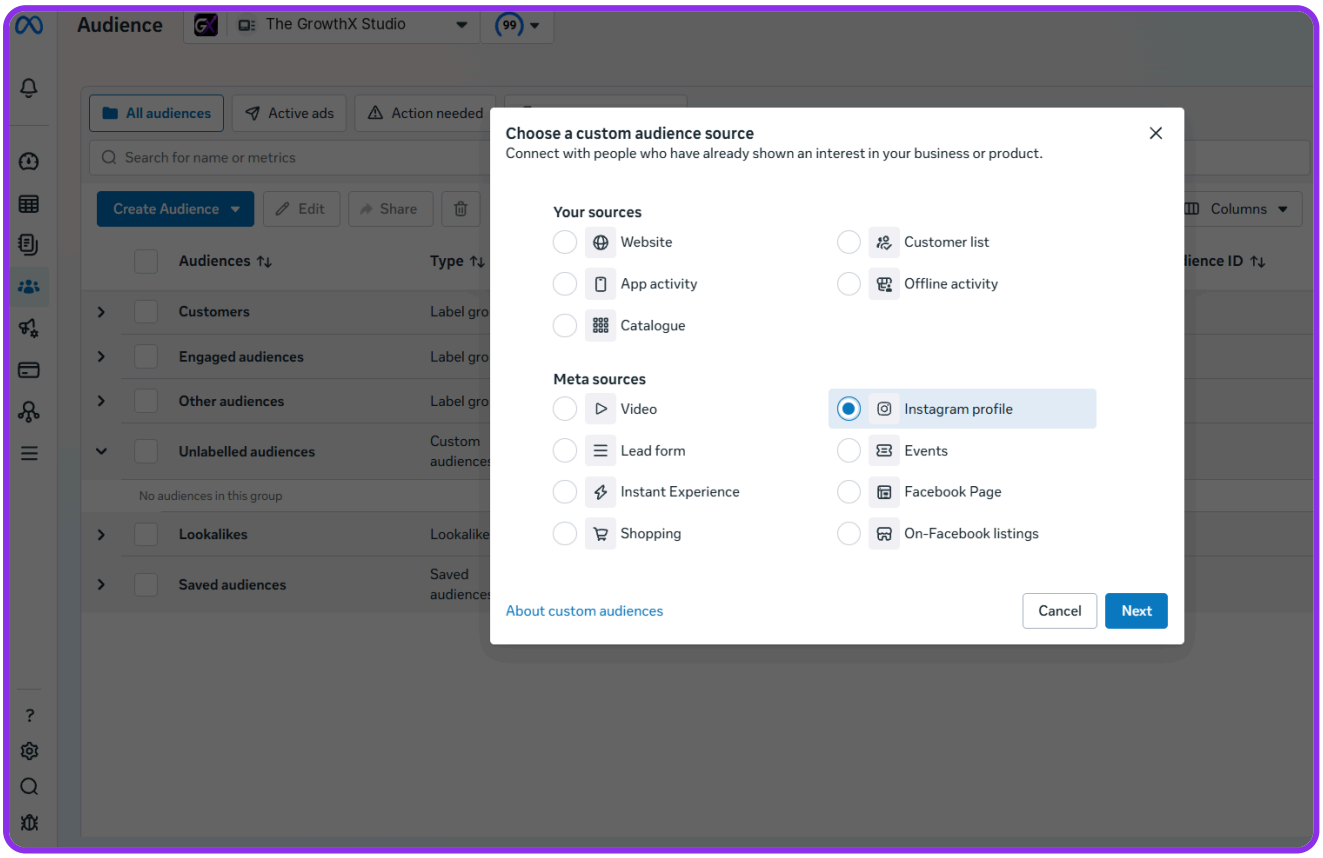
3. From the dropdown, choose **Custom Audience**.



STEP 2

Pick Instagram as the source

1 Under **Meta sources**, select **Instagram profile**, then click **Next**.



2 Choose your Instagram account. Under **Events**, pick **Everyone who engaged with this professional account**.

3 Set **Retention** to **180 days** (the maximum), so the audience is as big as possible.

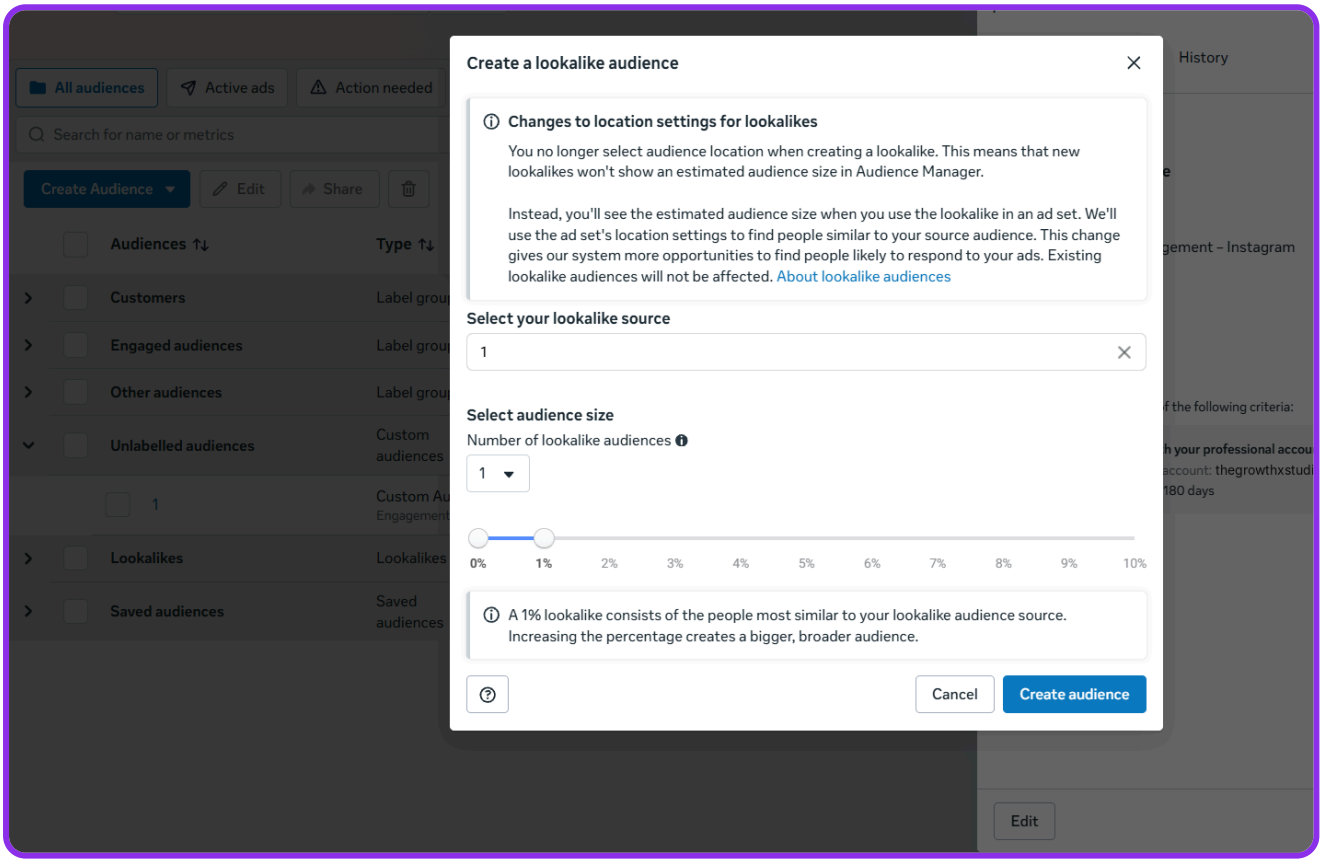
4 Name it clearly, e.g. **IG Engagers – 180D**, and click **Create audience**.

> **Tip:** Ads can't run to this audience until it has filled. Give it a few hours after creating it.

STEP 3

Turn it into a 1% Lookalike

1. Go back to **Create Audience** → **Lookalike audience**.
2. Under **Select your lookalike source**, choose the **IG Engagers – 180D** audience you just made.
3. Drag **audience size** to **1%**. That's the slice of people most similar to your source.



The 1% lookalike, from the source audience you just created.

Where's the location? Meta no longer asks for a country when you create a lookalike. You set the location (e.g. **India**) in the **ad set** instead, and Meta builds the lookalike inside it.

STEP 4

Add your competitor in Detailed Targeting

1. Create or edit your campaign's **ad set**. In **Audience**, add your **1% lookalike** under Custom Audiences.
2. Set **Location** to where you sell, e.g. **India**.
3. In **Detailed targeting**, search your competitor's brand name. If it shows up as an **Interest**, click to add it.
4. Didn't show up? That's normal for smaller brands. Try the bigger brands in your niche, or the category they sell in (e.g. "Skin care", "Streetwear").

> **Good to know:** With **Advantage+ audience** on, Meta treats your targeting as suggestions and may go wider when it finds better results. That's fine, because your lookalike and interests still steer it.

Example ad set

📍 **Location:** India · 👥 **Custom audience:** 1% Lookalike of IG Engagers
🎯 **Detailed targeting:** [Competitor brand] + [category interest] · 🎂 **Age:** as per your buyers
🚫 **Exclude:** past purchasers (if you have a customer list)

PRO TIPS

Get more out of it

1. **Test 1% vs 3%.** 1% is closest to your audience. 3–5% gives more reach once 1% is working.
2. **Stack more sources.** Build lookalikes from video viewers (75%+), website visitors and your customer list too.
3. **Keep the source fresh.** Post and run engagement content regularly so the IG engager audience keeps growing.
4. **Let it learn.** Give each ad set roughly 50 conversions or 5–7 days before judging it.
5. **Creative is the real lever.** Targeting gets you in front of the right people; the hook in the first 2 seconds makes them stop.

> **Stay compliant.** Only upload customer lists of people who gave *you* their details. Uploading scraped follower emails or phone numbers breaks Meta's Custom Audience terms and data-protection law (DPDP Act in India), and can get your ad account restricted.

Quick checklist

☐ IG Engagers – 180D custom audience created

☐ 1% lookalike created from it

☐ Ad set: location set, lookalike added

☐ Competitor brand / category interests added

☐ 2–3 strong creatives live



Want us to run this for your brand?

The GrowthX Studio plans, launches and scales Meta Ads for D2C and e-commerce brands.

Let's grow together.

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